

Sprint 2: Research & Strategy – StudyBuddy Hub

Target Audience

The primary target audience for *StudyBuddy Hub* is first-year tertiary education students at the University or College. These students are in their first year of higher education and are adjusting to a new academic environment, increased workload, and the need for self-directed learning. Many are also adapting to life away from home for the first time.

They often face:

- **Academic challenges** – adjusting to new teaching styles, managing multiple modules, and preparing for more rigorous assessments.
- **Financial constraints** – many rely on NSFAS funding or part-time work, making expensive study tools and textbooks unaffordable.
- **Social and emotional pressures** – building new friendships, dealing with homesickness, and managing stress.

Common characteristics of the primary audience:

- **Age Range:** 18–20 years old.
- **Location:** Primarily based in South Africa.
- **Technology Habits:** Heavy mobile phone use for communication, research, and accessing academic resources.
- **Needs:** Affordable or free, curriculum-specific study materials; opportunities to join study groups; reliable, organized resources for exam preparation.

Secondary audience:

Senior students who wish to share resources, mentor juniors, or collaborate on projects. While they are not the main focus, they can enrich the platform with quality content and guidance.

Personas

Primary Personas:

Persona 1: Sipho Madala

- **Age:** 18
- **Course:** BEng Electrical Engineering
- **Family Status:** Single, lives with family
- **Location:** Cape Flats (Khayelitsha)
- **Character:** The Determined Achiever
- **Personality:** Introvert, Thinking, Judging, Practical
- **Traits:** Dedicated, resourceful, detail-oriented, anxious

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Bio: Sipho is a first-generation student from Khayelitsha who commutes daily to tertiary education Bellville campus. He is quiet and spends most of his time in the library. While he's serious about his studies, he feels isolated and overwhelmed by the fast pace of first-year subjects.

Goals: Achieve high marks, secure a bursary or internship, and make his family proud by graduating.

Frustrations: He struggles to find reliable notes and past papers, cannot afford paid study platforms like Chegg, and has difficulty connecting with other students to study collaboratively.

Persona 2: Mary-Ann Peters

- **Age:** 19
- **Course:** BSc Environmental Science
- **Family Status:** Dependent on NSFAS, lives with single mother
- **Location:** Mitchells Plain
- **Character:** The Social Organizer
- **Personality:** Extrovert, Feeling, Intuitive, Organized
- **Traits:** Outgoing, organized, idealistic, multitasking

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Bio: Mary-Ann juggles university, a part-time job, and volunteer work. She's highly motivated and active in campus societies. However, her busy schedule makes it difficult to manage group work and access proper study materials.

Goals: Maintain good grades, build a support network, and find an internship in her field.

Frustrations: Difficulty organizing group study sessions, often receives disorganized study material, and cannot afford costly textbooks or premium study tools.

Secondary Personas:

Persona 3: Kyle Johnson

- **Age:** 22
- **Course:** BCom Management
- **Family Status:** Lives with parents, part-time worker
- **Location:** Somerset West
- **Character:** The Practical Networker
- **Personality:** Extrovert, Thinking, Perceiving, Adaptable
- **Traits:** Practical, tech-savvy, laid-back, social

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Bio: Kyle is a returning student who works part-time. He prefers practical over theoretical learning and uses online tools on his mobile phone. He often feels disconnected from university platforms and finds communication fragmented.

Goals: Graduate while maintaining a healthy work-life balance.

Frustrations: Poor internet access at home, irrelevant content on global study platforms, and struggles with unorganized WhatsApp groups for study purposes.

Persona 4: Zanele Ndlovu

- **Age:** 18
- **Course:** Diploma in Journalism
- **Family Status:** Lives in campus residence
- **Location:** Eastern Cape
- **Character:** The Creative Introvert
- **Personality:** Introvert, Feeling, Intuitive, Reflective
- **Traits:** Creative, shy, conscientious, visual learner

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Bio: Zanele is a new tertiary education student from the Eastern Cape. She feels overwhelmed by the shift to tertiary learning and often avoids asking for help. She uses free tools online but finds little content relevant to the South African curriculum.

Goals: Improve writing skills, contribute to the campus newspaper, and build confidence in class.

Frustrations: Lack of accessible examples for journalism assignments, difficulty forming study groups, and struggles to find content aligned with tertiary education modules.

Competitive Analysis

1. Studocu

- **Offerings:** Peer contributed study materials including notes, summaries, and past exam papers.
- **Pricing Model:** Free limited access or a premium plan (~R150–R250/month) for full features. Users can also earn access by uploading documents (Studocu, 2024).
- **Target Audience:** University students worldwide, especially in non-STEM subjects.
- **Strengths:** Large resource base, free access model with contribution system.
- **Weaknesses:** No expert checking of quality, limited South African curriculum content (Studocu, 2024).

2. Chegg Study

- **Offerings:** Expert Q&A, textbook solutions, plagiarism checkers, and math problem solvers.
- **Pricing Model:** Monthly subscription (~R280) with no free tier after trial (Chegg, 2024).
- **Target Audience:** Students in math, science, business, and engineering fields.
- **Strengths:** Verified, expert reviewed content, useful for complex subjects.
- **Weaknesses:** Entirely paid service, expensive for South African students, no focus on local curriculum (Chegg, 2024).

3. Course Hero

- **Offerings:** Student uploaded materials with access unlocks via uploads or subscription. Also offers tutoring and expert answers.
- **Pricing Model:** Subscriptions range from ~\$10–\$40/month, limited free use via document uploads (Course Hero, 2024).
- **Target Audience:** Global students looking for written assignments, practice papers, and essays.
- **Strengths:** Wide subject coverage and flexible access options.
- **Weaknesses:** Inconsistent content quality, few South African materials, confusing unlock system (Course Hero, 2024).

4. Quizlet (*Honourable Mention*)

- **Offerings:** Flashcard based learning with games and memorization tools.
- **Pricing Model:** Free and premium versions (~R850/year for Quizlet Plus).
- **Target Audience:** General students, especially language learners.
- **Strengths:** Simple, gamified learning.
- **Weaknesses:** Doesn't offer deep study materials, not tailored to university level or tertiary education specific content (Quizlet, 2024).

Opportunities for Differentiation

StudyBuddy Hub can stand out by addressing specific tertiary education needs and the financial realities of South African students:

1. Local Curriculum Focus

Unlike global platforms, StudyBuddy Hub will feature tertiary education specific modules and content, including past papers and assignments from actual students. This solves the issue where international platforms don't align with local curricula (EduResearch Africa, 2024).

2. Free, Peer-to-Peer Model

Students will be able to share and download content for free, removing financial barriers that exist on platforms like Chegg and Course Hero (Chegg, 2024; Course Hero, 2024). It promotes a culture of collaboration, not profit.

3. Community & Support

The platform will encourage students to join module-specific study groups, making it easier to connect and learn together. Unlike fragmented WhatsApp groups, StudyBuddy Hub offers structured and moderated spaces, boosting trust and participation (Sipho Persona, 2025).

4. Mobile & Low-Data Friendly

Recognizing that many students lack stable Wi-Fi, StudyBuddy Hub will offer offline downloads and avoid video-heavy content, supporting low-bandwidth access – something missing in most global platforms (EduResearch Africa, 2024).

5. Local Identity & Trust

Created by and for tertiary education students, the platform uses relatable language and content. It can even support multilingual notes (e.g., English/Xhosa/Afrikaans), ensuring relevance and inclusion (Mary-Ann Persona, 2025).

Conclusion

StudyBuddy Hub fills the gap left by global study platforms by offering localised, free, and collaborative learning tools tailored to tertiary education's unique student body. It will address financial and social barriers through an inclusive and community-driven approach. While global platforms like Chegg and Course Hero are helpful for students who can afford them, StudyBuddy Hub is designed for real students, real problems, and real solutions – all built around the tertiary education experience.

References

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